

Client Discovery Questionnaire

The questions to ask before you open a design file, so you're solving the right problem the first time.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Designers meeting a new client for the first time, or starting a new project with an existing one, who want structured answers instead of a vague verbal brief.

HOW TO USE IT

Send this ahead of a kickoff call so the client has time to think, then walk through the answers together — the follow-up conversation usually surfaces more than the written answers alone.

1. THE BUSINESS

In your own words, what does your business do, and for whom?

How long has the business been running, and what's changed recently?

Who are your 2–3 biggest competitors, and what do you think they do better than you?

2. THE CUSTOMER

Describe your ideal customer as a real person — age, situation, what they care about.

What do customers say when they explain why they chose you?

What objection or hesitation comes up most before someone buys?

3. THE PROJECT

What made you decide to start this project now?

What does success look like when this is finished — be as concrete as possible.

Is there a past design (yours or someone else's) that failed, and why do you think it did?

4. TASTE & DIRECTION

Name 2–3 brands, in or outside your industry, whose look you admire — and say what specifically you like.

Is there anything you definitely don't want — colors, styles, comparisons to avoid?

5. PRACTICAL DETAILS

Decision-maker for final approval

Hard deadline, if one exists, and why it's fixed

Confirmed budget range

Where the finished work will be used (print, web, signage, social, packaging)

IN THE FOLLOW-UP CALL

Listen for gaps between what the client says and what they've actually built so far — a mismatch there is usually the real project, even if it's not what they asked for.

NEXT STEPS

Keep completed questionnaires on file for every client. Six months into a working relationship, this document is often the fastest way to settle a disagreement about what was actually agreed at the start.